



China Internet & New Media

Global Markets Research

29 June 2026

EQUITY: INTERNET & NEW MEDIA

Monthly App Tracker – May 2026

China's Instagram, Xiaohongshu, registers first-ever decline in time spent

MAS rose 1.2% y-y and total monthly time spent increased 10.1% y-y in May

Monthly active smartphone (MAS) users in China rose 1.2% y-y to 1.28bn in May 2026. China's MAS has remained stable in recent months. Total monthly time spent (MTS) grew 10.1% y-y in May, largely on par with the 10.3% y-y growth in April 2026.

Ecommerce apps showed lukewarm growth despite 618 promotions

The MTS of Taobao app [owned by Alibaba (BABA US, Buy)] and JD (JD US, Buy) app rebounded by 17% and 19% sequentially, respectively, in May, driven by 618 promotions (which started in mid-May). But the y-y trend looks lackluster – Taobao's MTS in May rose only 7% y-y, while JD's declined 10% from a high base a year ago when it launched the food delivery business followed by substantial investment in user acquisition. In terms of DAU (daily active users), Taobao recorded modest 1% y-y growth, while JD's declined 3% y-y. For PDD (PDD US, Neutral), MTS rose 13% y-y and 3% m-m – PDD business is not as prone to 618 promotions as the platform has a low-price strategy throughout the year.

The weakness in the China ecommerce market will likely be reflected in soft ecommerce sales for the June quarter to be reported by our covered ecommerce platforms. Nomura projects an 8% decline in customer management revenue (CMR) for Alibaba and a 7% decline in JDR's revenue in the June quarter. Please see our [BABA preview note](#) for more detailed discussions.

Weakening user engagement with the travel-booking apps

The user engagement of the travel sector deteriorated further into May. The MTS of Trip.com's (TCOM US, Neutral) two China apps Ctrip and Qunar in May fell 19% and 14% y-y, respectively, weighed down by 9% and 13% declines of DAU. Fliggy (owned by BABA) saw a bigger 15% y-y decline, mainly due to an 11% drop of DAU. Even the state-backed ticketing app Umetrip (unlisted) was not immune to this weakness, reversing the growth trend of previous months and ending May with flat year-over-year MTS. We believe the hikes in air fuel surcharge likely resulted in the weakness.

Xiaohongshu registers the first-ever decline in time spent

According to Questmobile, the MTS of Xiaohongshu (XHS, unlisted) declined 1% y-y, the first-ever decline since we began tracking its app in 2020. The decline was a combined result of 3% growth of DAU and a 4% drop of average daily time spent per DAU (DTSD). We think XHS is likely experiencing the same "AI headwind" as other information portals like search – users are increasingly switching to AI chatbots for information and knowledge discovery which poses a threat to the core value proposition offered by XHS. XHS has secured an exclusive online streaming right for the FIFA World Cup 2026 in China, which we believe is likely aimed at broadening its demographic reach and further drive the user growth. Based on Questmobile, the DAU of XHS reached 122mn in May 2026, up 3% y-y.

DeepSeek returned to second position in native AI chatbot field

According to Questmobile, Doubao (owned by Bytedance) appeared to have further widened its lead in the crowded field of AI chatbots with DAU growth of 5% m-m and 3.6x y-y, reaching 158mn. Following the successful release of DeepSeek - V4 models in late April, DeepSeek's consumer app climbed to the second position with DAU standing at 30.5mn, up by 6% m-m, surpassing Qwen app (owned by BABA) at 27.9mn (down 5% m-m but up 76.6x from a low base a year ago). Additionally, Ant's AI assistant, Afu, saw impressive user growth with DAU rising 11% m-m to 5.1mn, likely driven by the launch of a free consultation service that interprets users' medical checkup reports.

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Production Complete: 2026-06-29 15:12 UTC

Overview of leading Chinese apps

Much of the traffic flow in May 2026 was dominated by apps owned by Bytedance, Tencent (700 HK, Buy), Baidu (BIDU US, Buy), and Alibaba. In particular, Bytedance's apps took five spots among the Top-20 in terms of both monthly active users (MAU) and time spent share in May, according to QuestMobile. Tencent's WeChat alone recorded an 19.0% share in terms of time spent by Chinese mobile users, leading the next two apps – Douyin and Douyin Lite (both unlisted, owned by Bytedance) – with 18.7% and 6.3% time-spent share, respectively.

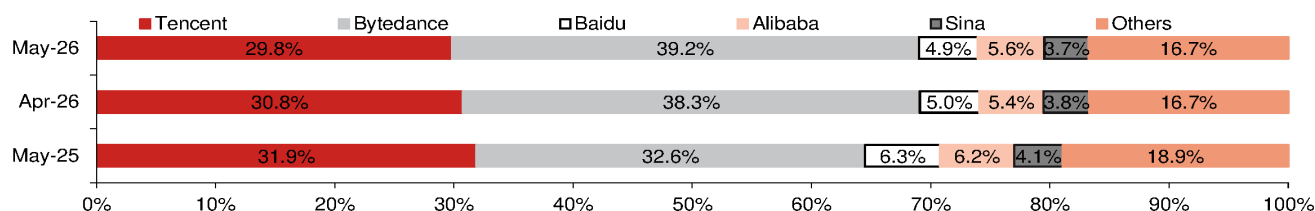
Fig. 1: Top-20 apps in China, by MAU and time spent – May

Top 20 Apps in MAU: MAUs change and penetration					Time spent share for top 20 Chinese mobile apps in May				
App Name	Rank M-M chg	Penetration	Penetration Y-Y	Penetration M-M	App Name	Rank M-M chg	Time spent share	Time spent share Y-Y	Time spent share M-M
WeChat	-	90.1%	2.8ppt	0.9ppt	WeChat	-	19.0%	-1.5ppt	-0.4ppt
Douyin	-	80.4%	8.7ppt	1.0ppt	Douyin	-	18.7%	2.6ppt	0.6ppt
Taobao	-	77.1%	-0.4ppt	2.1ppt	Douyin Lite	-	6.3%	1.2ppt	0.1ppt
Alipay	-	73.6%	0.3ppt	0.5ppt	Red Fruit Free Short Drama	↑	4.0%	2.1ppt	0.3ppt
Amap	-	72.4%	0.5ppt	1.0ppt	Kuaishou	↓	3.9%	-0.9ppt	0.0ppt
Pinduoduo	-	55.8%	0.7ppt	-0.4ppt	Sogou Keyboard	-	3.1%	-0.1ppt	-0.1ppt
Sogou Keyboard	-	54.4%	4.4ppt	-0.1ppt	Toutiao	-	2.8%	-0.4ppt	-0.1ppt
JD	↑	50.7%	1.5ppt	3.3ppt	Pinduoduo	-	2.3%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
Baidu	↓	50.7%	-5.3ppt	-0.1ppt	rednote	-	2.2%	-0.3ppt	0.0ppt
QQ	↓	49.4%	-0.8ppt	0.9ppt	Kuaishou Express	-	2.2%	-0.4ppt	0.0ppt
Baidu Maps	-	44.8%	-2.1ppt	0.9ppt	Baidu Keyboard	-	2.1%	-0.3ppt	0.1ppt
Meituan	-	40.9%	0.7ppt	0.5ppt	Weibo	-	2.0%	-0.3ppt	0.0ppt
Weibo	↑	38.7%	-0.3ppt	1.5ppt	Fangjie Free Novels	-	1.9%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
Baidu Keyboard	↓	38.7%	-0.8ppt	0.3ppt	Taobao	-	1.9%	-0.1ppt	0.2ppt
Kuaishou	-	35.3%	-1.2ppt	0.1ppt	Bilibili	-	1.7%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
Toutiao	-	29.9%	-1.0ppt	0.4ppt	Sina News	-	1.5%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
Doubao	-	28.9%	18.5ppt	0.8ppt	Baidu	-	1.5%	-0.6ppt	0.0ppt
Red Fruit Free Short Dram	↑	27.9%	12.1ppt	1.7ppt	Honour of Kings	-	1.3%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
QQ Browser	↓	26.8%	-6.8ppt	-0.9ppt	Alipay	-	1.2%	0.1ppt	0.0ppt
Douyin Lite	-	26.0%	3.5ppt	0.1ppt	Tencent News	-	1.1%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Among the Top-50 apps, which accounted for ~93% of the total mobile time spent in China during May, we note that the Bytedance camp gained time-spent share on a y-y basis, which rose from 32.6% in May 2025 to 39.2% in May 2026, surpassing Tencent camp's 29.8%. Sequentially, Bytedance's time-spent share was up 0.8ppt m-m.

Fig. 2: Time-spent share of various internet camps among the Top-50 apps in China



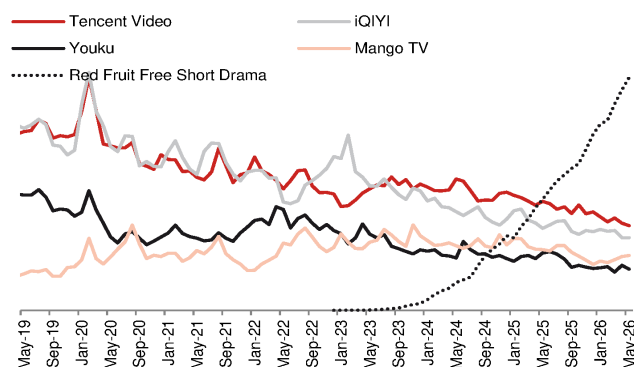
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Long-form vs short-form dramas

Long-form video apps remained weak in May. The MTS of Tencent Video (owned by Tencent) recorded a 31% y-y decline in May, dragged by a 22% decline in DAU and an 11% decline in DTSD. Youku (owned by BABA)/Mango TV (300413 CH, Not rated)/iQIYI (IQ US, Neutral) recorded 36%/5%/6% y-y declines in total time spent, mainly dragged by 28%/10%/12% declines in DAU.

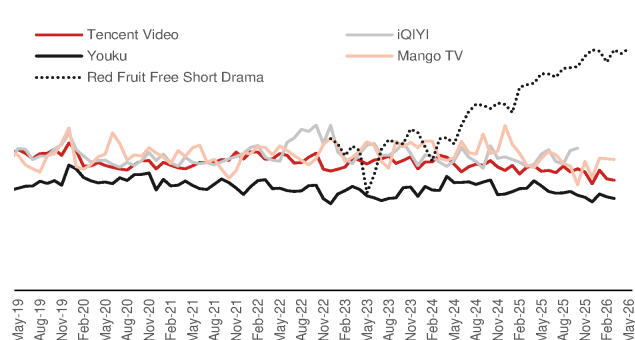
The dominant short-form drama app – Red Fruit Free Short Drama – kept its strong growth trend with an MTS increase of 134%, backed by 110% growth in DAU and 11% growth in DTSD.

Fig. 3: DAUs of long-form vs short-form dramas apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 4: Average daily time spent per user

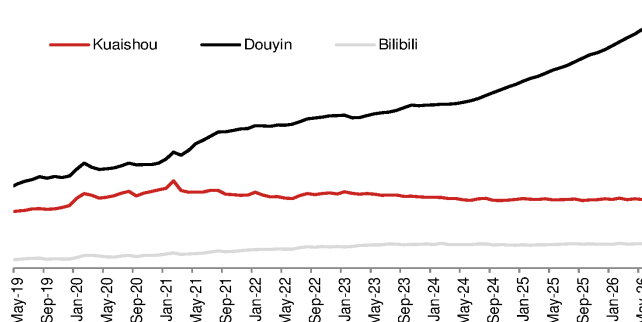


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Short video

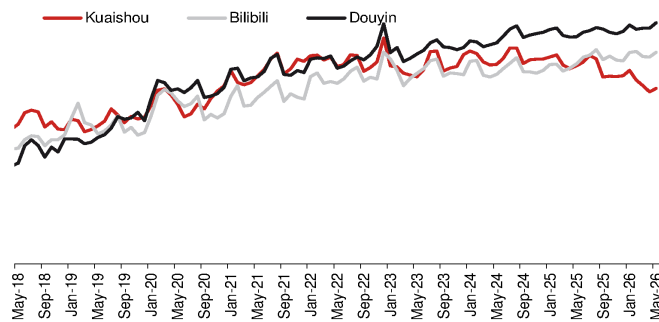
In May, Douyin maintained its solid growth momentum in terms of MTS, at 28% y-y, mainly driven by 21% growth in DAU. Total time spent for Bilibili (BILI US, Neutral) recorded 10% y-y growth in May, driven by 4% y-y growth in DAU and 6% growth in DTSD. However, Kuaishou (1024 HK, Neutral) continued its relatively soft performance, with a decline of 11% y-y in MTS, mainly dragged by an 11% y-y decline in DTSD.

Fig. 5: DAUs of short video apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 6: Average daily time spent per user

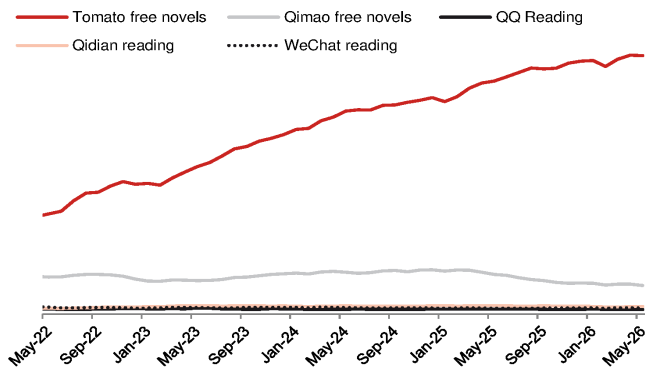


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

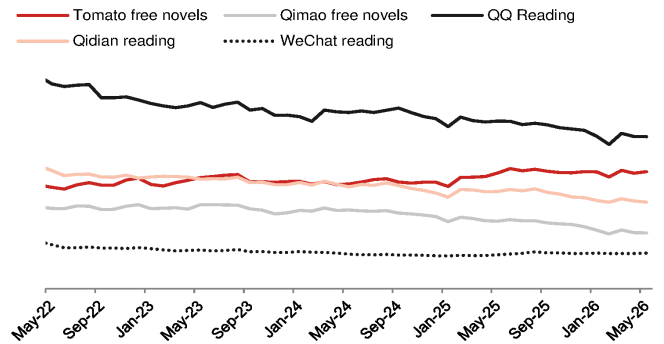
Online reading

The MTS of the free reading app leader Tomato Free Novels (unlisted; owned by ByteDance) maintained its solid growth momentum, up 12% y-y in May, driven by increases of 11% y-y in DAU. Another free reading app, Qimao Free Novels (unlisted), recorded a 41% y-y decline in total time spent, dragged by 28% and 17% y-y declines in DAU and DTSD, respectively.

Paid reading apps owned by China Literature (772 HK, Buy), i.e., Qidian reading and QQ reading, recorded respective declines of 11% and 8% on a y-y basis in DAU during the month, while their DTSDs were down by 11% and 9% y-y, respectively.

Fig. 7: DAU of online reading platforms

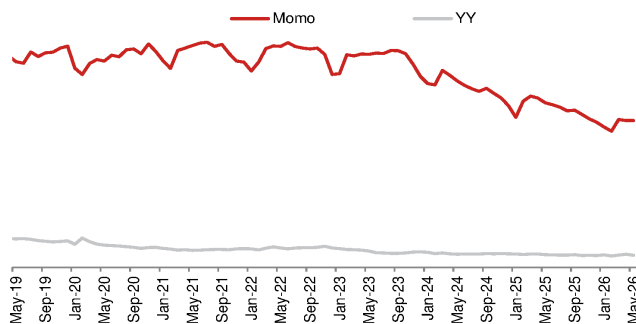
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 8: Average daily time spent per DAU of online reading platforms

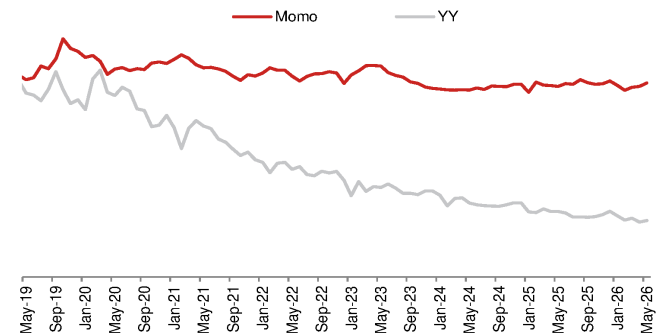
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Live broadcasting

Live broadcasting show apps maintained their y-y downward trend in MTS in May. The DAU of Momo (MOMO US, Not rated) and YY (owned by Baidu) declined by 11% and 5% y-y, respectively. In terms of DTSD, Momo was up 2% y-y, while YY recorded a 14% y-y decline during the month.

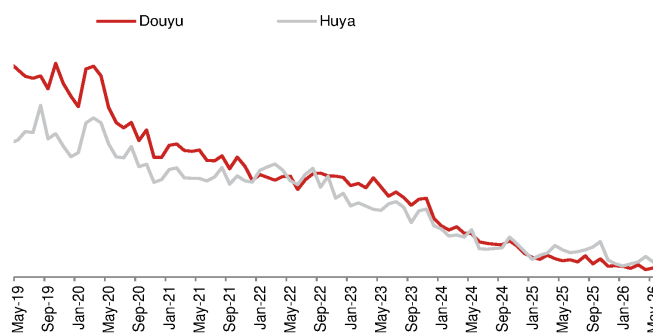
Fig. 9: DAUs of live broadcasting show apps

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

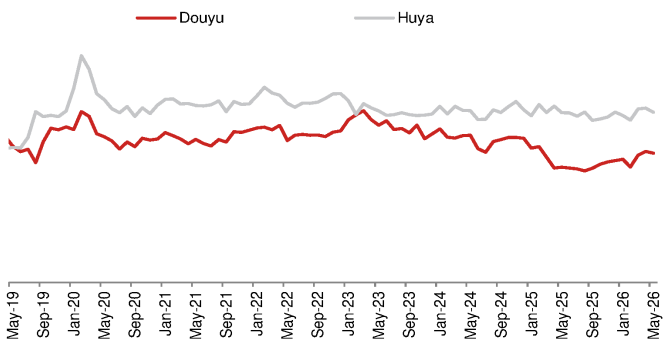
Fig. 10: Average daily time spent per user

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

For game live broadcasting apps, the MTS for Huya (HUYA US, Not rated) recorded a 14% decline in May, mainly dragged by a 15% y-y decline in DAU. The MTS for Douyu (DOYU US, Not rated) recovered to 1% y-y growth in May, driven by 12% y-y growth in DTSD, offsetting 10% y-y decline in DAU.

Fig. 11: DAUs of game live broadcasting apps

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 12: Average daily time spent per user

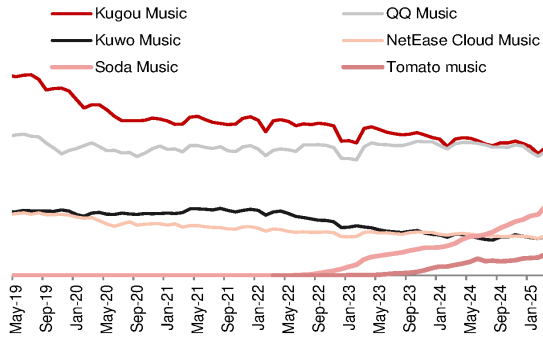
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Music

The y-y decline in DAU continued for most part of the music universe, except for Soda Music and Tomato Music (both owned by ByteDance), which recorded 79% and 57% y-y growth in May. The DAU of NetEase Cloud Music (9899 HK, Not rated) recorded flat y-y in May. QQ Music/Kugou Music/Kuwo Music [owned by TME (TME US, Buy)] decreased 4%/12%/13% y-y in terms of DAU in May (as shown in [Fig. 13](#)).

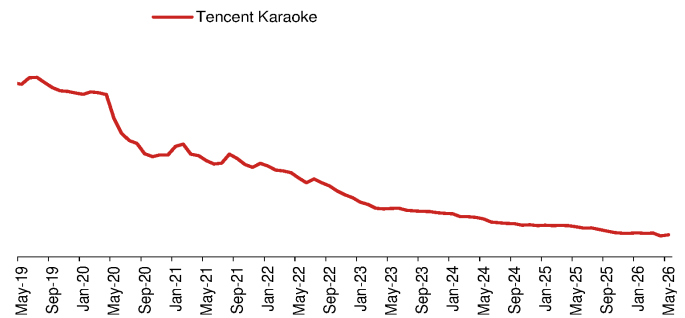
Tencent Karaoke maintained its y-y downward trend in MTS, with a 23% y-y decline, mainly dragged by a 27% y-y drop in DAU, offsetting 7% y-y growth in DTSD in May (as shown in [Fig. 14](#)).

Fig. 13: DAUs of music streaming apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 14: DAUs of online karaoke app

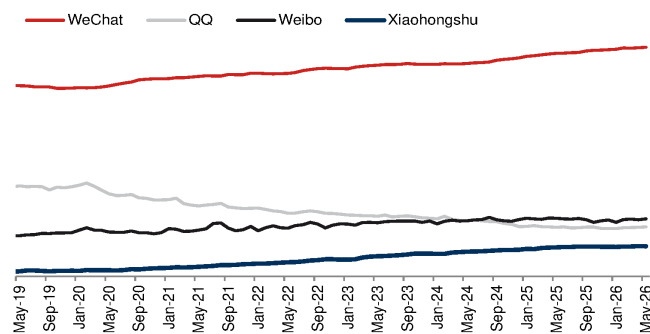


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Social

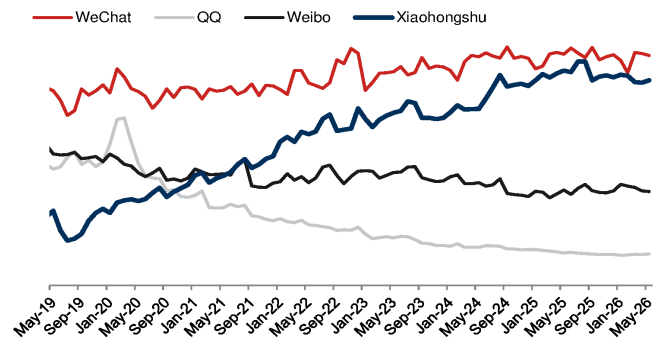
The MTS of Xiaohongshu (unlisted) saw 1% y-y decline for the first time in May, dragged by a 4% y-y decline in DTSD, offsetting 3% growth in DAU. The MTS of Weibo (WB US, Neutral) declined 3% y-y in May, dragged by 2%/1% decline in DTSD and DAU, respectively. Within Tencent's social ecosystem, QQ maintained its downward trend in MTS, with a 3% y-y decline, while WeChat recorded 2% y-y growth in terms of total time spent in May.

Fig. 15: DAUs of social apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 16: Average daily time spent per user

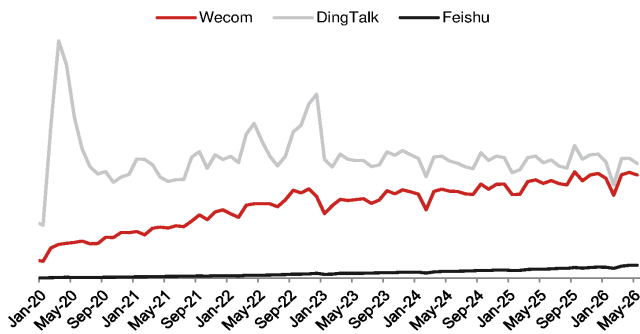


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Office apps

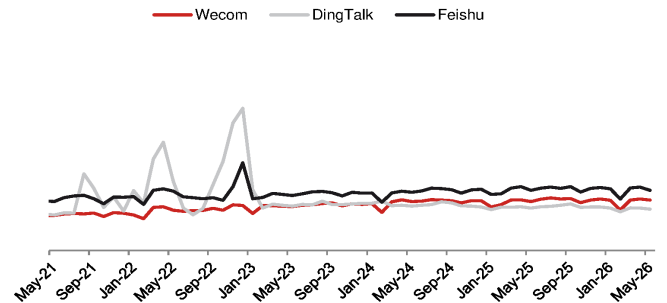
Within the office apps vertical, the DAU of Feishu (owned by Bytedance) and Wecom (owned by Tencent) recorded 45% y-y and 9% y-y growth, respectively, in May, while Ding Talk (owned by BABA) declined by 1% y-y. However, Ding Talk owned the largest DAU base at ~80mn, which was 1.1x and 9.0x that of Wecom and Feishu, respectively. For Feishu, the DTSD was at 14.2 minutes (flat y-y), followed by Wecom's 11.9 minutes (up 3% y-y) and DingTalk's 9.7 minutes (down 2% y-y), as per QuestMobile data.

Fig. 17: DAUs of office business apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 18: Average daily time spent per user

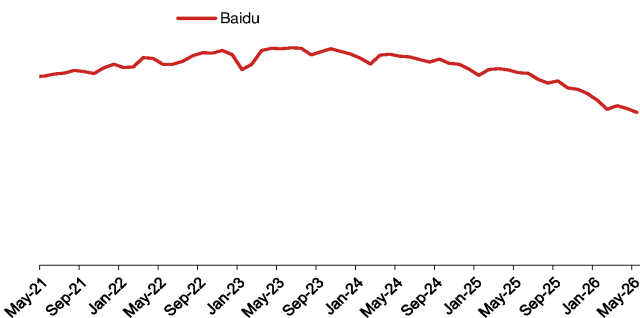


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Search

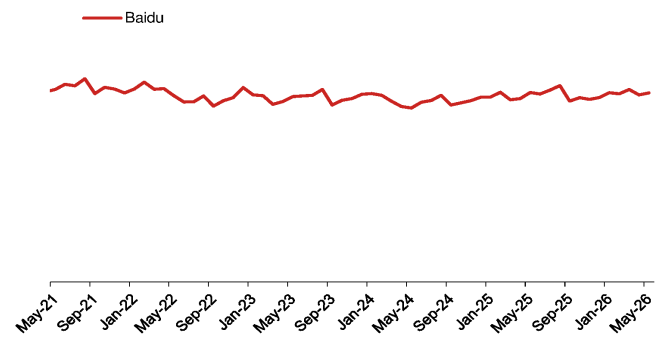
The Baidu app, despite being a dominant search engine in China, witnessed a 21% y-y decline in MTS during the month, dragged by a 21% y-y decline in DAU.

Fig. 19: DAU of Baidu app



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 20: Average daily time spent per user



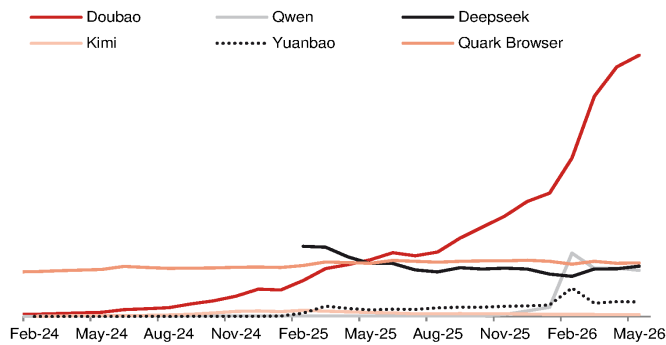
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

AI tools

The DAU of Doubao (owned by ByteDance) ranked first in May at 158mn (according to QuestMobile data), representing 3.6x y-y and 5% m-m growth. This was followed by Quark Browser at 32mn (up 1% y-y and 1% m-m), Deepseek at 31mn (down 5% y-y and up 6% m-m), and Qwen (owned by Alibaba) at 28mn (up 77x y-y and down 5% m-m).

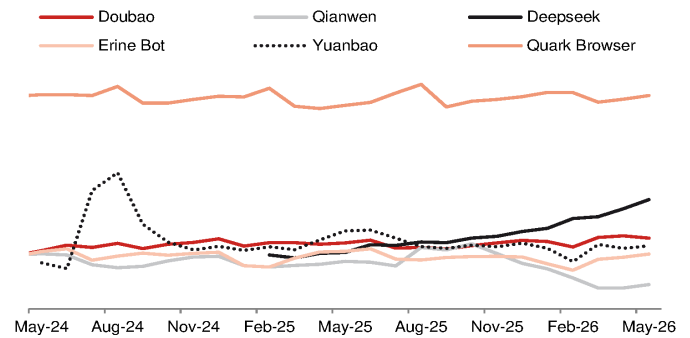
In terms of DTSD, Quark Browser recorded the highest time spent at 33.5 minutes in May (up 5% y-y and 2% m-m). Deepseek ranked the second at 17.2 minutes (up 94% y-y and 9% m-m), followed by Zhipu Qingyan's 11.8 minutes (up 67% y-y and 3% m-m), Kimi's 11.6 minutes (up 61% y-y and 21% m-m), and Doubao's 11.1 minutes (up 7% y-y and down 3% m-m).

Fig. 21: DAUs of AI apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 22: Average daily time spent per DAU of AI apps

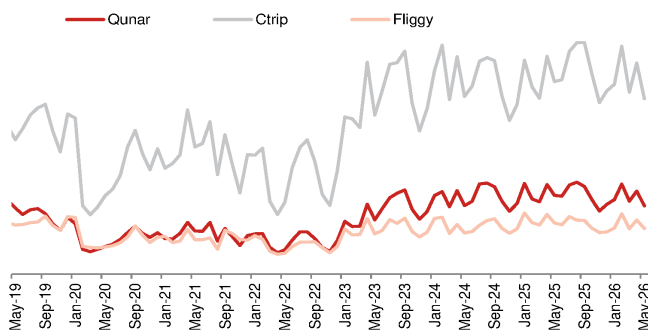


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Online travel

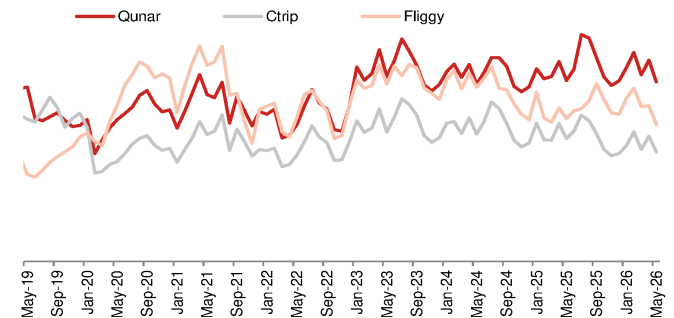
Among online travel apps, TRIP.com's domestic apps, Ctrip and Qunar, and Fliggy (unlisted, owned by BABA) recorded 19%/14%/15% y-y declines in MTS in May, mainly dragged by 9%/13%/11% y-y declines in DAU respectively. In terms of DTSD, Ctrip and Qunar, and Fliggy recorded 11%/1%/4% y-y declines in May.

Fig. 23: DAUs of online travel apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 24: Average daily time spent per user

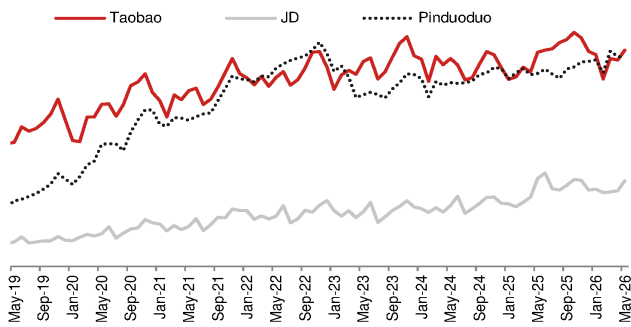


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

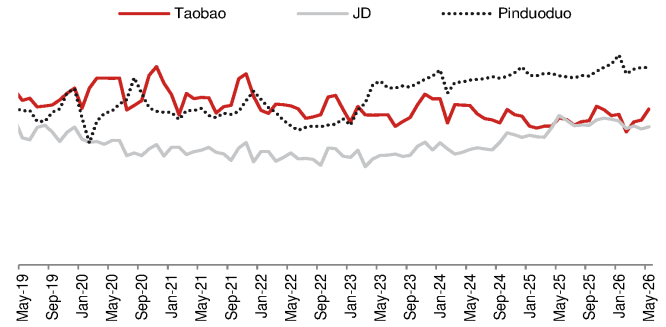
E-commerce

Pinduoduo (PDD US, Neutral) app and Alibaba's Taobao app were the top-two e-commerce names in terms of users and total time spent. In May, Taobao's DAU increase of 1% y-y was mainly driven by 3% growth in the number of casual users (daily time spent <1 minute), while the number of hardcore users (daily time spent >1 minute) recorded flat y-y. Pinduoduo's DAU recorded 8% y-y growth in May, backed by 27% y-y growth in the number of casual users and 4% growth in the number of hardcore users. However, JD app's DAU decreased 3% y-y, dragged by 12% y-y decline in the number of hardcore users, offsetting 30% y-y growth in the number of casual users.

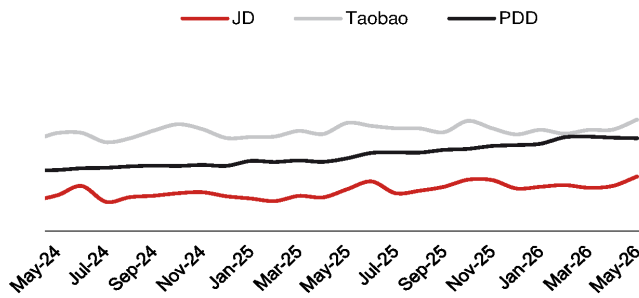
In terms of DTSD, Taobao and PDD delivered 6%/4% y-y growth, respectively, in May, while JD app recorded an 8% y-y decline.

Fig. 25: DAUs of China e-commerce apps

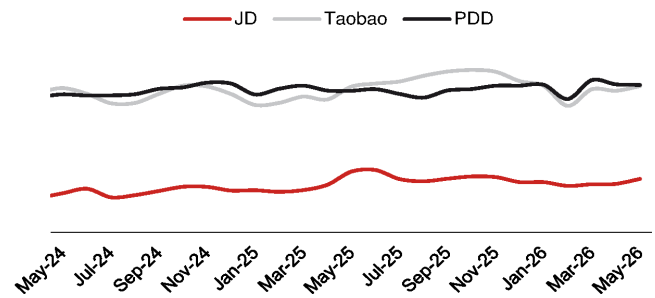
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 26: Average daily time spent per user

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 27: Number of users with daily time spent at <1 minute

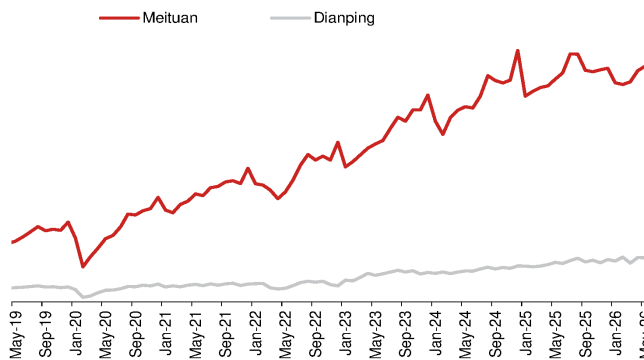
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 28: Number of users with daily time spent at >1 minute

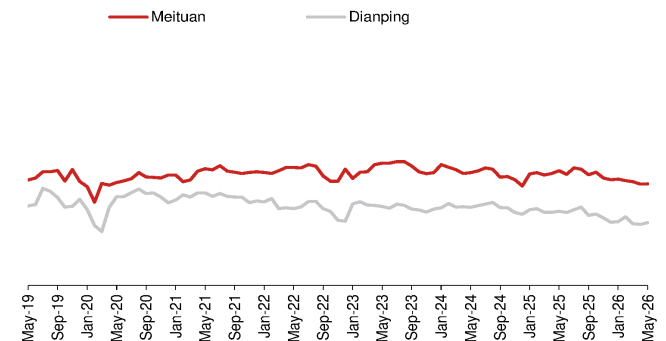
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

O2O

The Meituan app recorded a 6% y-y decline in MTS in May, dragged by a 12% decline in DTSD, offsetting 6% growth in DAU. Dianping app (owned by Meituan) recorded a 6% decline in MTS, dragged by a 15% y-y decline in DTSD, offsetting 12% growth in DAU.

Fig. 29: DAUs of Meituan and Dianping

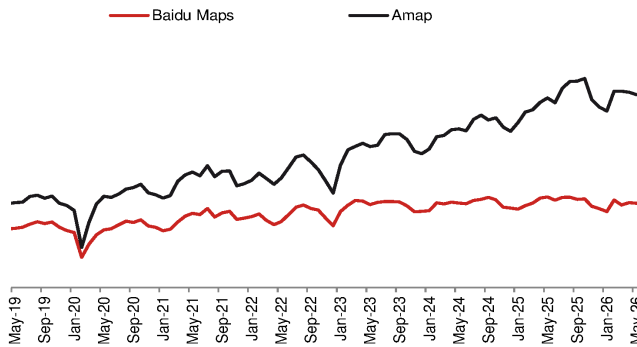
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 30: Average daily time spent per user

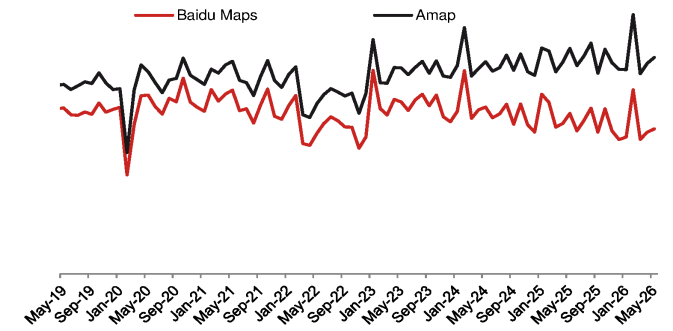
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Mobile map apps

Total time spent on Baidu Maps (owned by Baidu) declined 16% y-y in May, dragged by a 10% decline in DTSD and a 7% decline in DAU. The MTS of Amap (owned by BABA) recorded 3% y-y decline in May, dragged by 4% y-y decline in DTSD, offsetting 2% y-y increase in DAU.

Fig. 31: DAUs of Baidu Maps and Amap

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

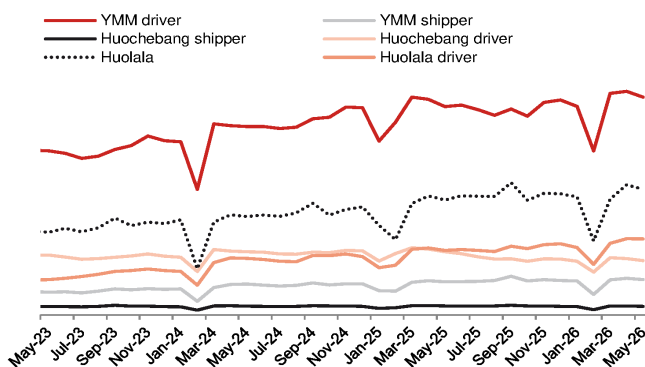
Fig. 32: Average daily time spent per user

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

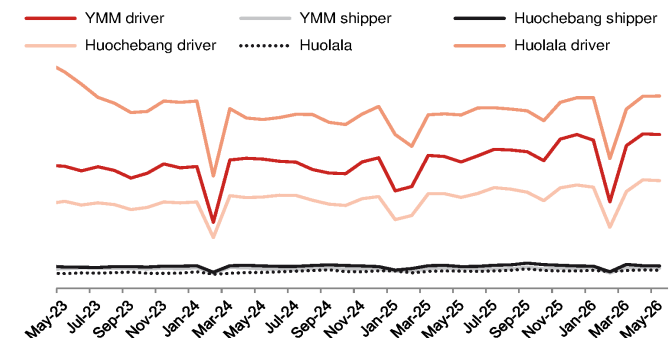
Digital freight apps

On the shipper side, the MTS of YMM Shipper (owned by Full Truck Alliance, FTA [YMM US, Buy]) and Huolala (unlisted) recorded 10% y-y and 14% y-y growth, respectively, in May. However, Huochebang Shipper (owned by FTA) recorded a 2% y-y decline in May, dragged by 4% decline in DAU, offsetting a 3% y-y growth in DTSD.

On the driver side, YMM Driver (owned by FTA)/Huolala Driver (unlisted) recorded 27%/31% y-y growth in MTS in May, accelerating from 21%/25% y-y growth in April, mainly driven by 22%/11% y-y growth in DTSD. Huochebang Driver (owned by FTA) recorded a 1% y-y growth in MTS, driven by an 18% growth in DTSD, offsetting 14% y-y decline in DAU.

Fig. 33: DAUs of digital freight apps

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

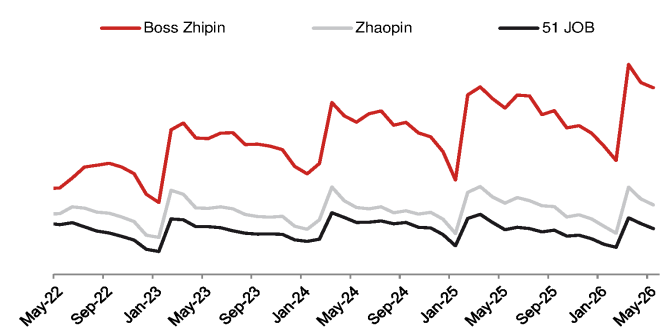
Fig. 34: Average daily time spent per user

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Online recruitment apps

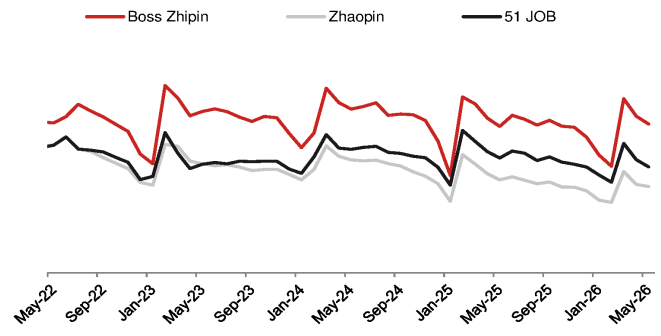
Boss Zhipin app (owned by Kanzhun [BZ US, Not rated]), a leading player in the online recruitment industry, recorded 14% y-y growth in MTS in May, mainly driven by 12% y-y growth in DAU. The MTS of Zhaopin (unlisted) decreased 10% y-y in May, dragged by an 7% decline in DTSD and 2% drop in DAU. Another peer, 51Job (unlisted), reported a 6% y-y decline in MTS in May, dragged by an 8% y-y decline in DTSD, offsetting 3% y-y growth in DAU.

Fig. 35: DAUs of online recruitment apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 36: Average daily time spent per user



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Appendix A-1

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